

ASCENDING BY THE SPIRIT

Not by Babel's Way

Screenplay

Written by

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FADE IN:

INT. FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY (FLASHBACK)

A modest but full house. Toys, shoes, and laughter fill the frame. A RADIO plays an upbeat song. A THREE-YEAR-OLD BOY (CHRIS, 3) stands on a coffee table, singing along note-for-note, dancing with total abandon.

His MOTHER watches from the kitchen doorway, dish towel in hand, stunned and smiling.

MOTHER

Lord have mercy. Would you look at that.

An OLDER SIBLING leans against the wall, grinning.

OLDER SIBLING

He's got it. He really does.

NARRATOR (V.O.) begins over the image – this is ADULT CHRIS, telling his own story.

NARRATOR (V.O.): I was born premature. Nobody expected much out of me at first. But at three years old, they already knew – this one could sing. This one could move.

INT. FAMILY HOME - VARIOUS ROOMS - DAY (FLASHBACK)

A house stretched thin by too many people and not enough space. Bunk beds crammed three to a room. A single bathroom with a line forming outside it most mornings. MOTHER stands at a stove stretching a pot of something to feed everyone, counting bowls under her breath. A stack of unopened envelopes sits on the counter – bills, mostly. The lights flicker once. Nobody reacts. This is normal.

NARRATOR (V.O.): We didn't have much room, and some months we didn't have much of anything. But my mother made it stretch. Nobody went to bed hungry. Nobody went without a roof. That was its own kind of miracle,

*even if I didn't call it that
back then.*

EXT. NEIGHBORHOOD STREET - DAY (FLASHBACK)

YOUNG CHRIS (8-10) rides a bike down a cracked sidewalk, laughing, wind in his face. Cut to: Chris kneeling at a fish tank, carefully arranging gravel and plants. Cut to: Chris at a lake with a fishing rod, grinning at a small catch.

*NARRATOR (V.O.): Eight siblings,
and a baby sister my mother took
in as her own. We never had
everything, but we always had a
roof and a plate at the table. I
was a homebody, mostly. But when
I got outside – my bike, my fish
tanks, fishing at the lake –
that was pure joy. Untouched.
For a little while.*

In the far background, barely noticeable, a SHADOW FIGURE stands at the edge of the frame beneath a dead tree – still, watching, gone in the next cut. It will return.

INT. FAMILY HOME - KITCHEN - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

YOUNG CHRIS (11) creeps toward a small home bar in the corner of the kitchen. He glances over his shoulder, then pours wine into a plastic cup with shaking, curious hands. He drinks. Coughs. Drinks again.

*NARRATOR (V.O.): At eleven, I
found my mother's wine. I didn't
know it then, but that night
opened a door I would spend
years walking back through.*

CUT TO:

**INT. COUSIN'S HOUSE - BEDROOM - DAY (FLASHBACK) - HANDLED
WITH RESTRAINT**

The room is still. YOUNG CHRIS sits alone on the edge of a bed afterward, staring at nothing, small and frozen. This moment is shown only through his face – no explicit

depiction. The camera holds on his eyes, then slowly pulls back, leaving him smaller in the frame.

NARRATOR (V.O.): I was molested by my own cousin. I didn't have words for it then. All I knew was that something in me had been rearranged – and that this was somehow, now, allowed to be normal. That lie took root and grew into more than one addiction.

EXT. FAMILY HOME - DRIVEWAY - SUNDAY MORNING (FLASHBACK)

A bright YELLOW CAR pulls up outside. YOUNG CHRIS (13), hair combed, in his best shirt, comes bounding out the front door before it even fully stops. AUNT (50s, warm but no-nonsense) leans over and pushes open the passenger door for him.

AUNT
Well don't just stand there,
you're gonna make us late.

Chris grins and climbs in. The car pulls away.

NARRATOR (V.O.): I was thirteen the first time my aunt took me to church. She saw it – saw that I needed something nobody else in the house was giving me. Parental guidance. Somebody to point me somewhere besides just surviving.

INT. CHURCH SANCTUARY - SUNDAY MORNING (FLASHBACK)

The sanctuary is modest but full of life – a choir swaying, hands raised, an old upright piano being played hard and joyfully. YOUNG CHRIS sits beside his AUNT, wide-eyed, drawn in despite himself, his foot tapping along without him noticing. For the first time in the film, his face is unguarded – just a kid, genuinely happy to be somewhere.

NARRATOR (V.O.): I loved it. I didn't fully understand what I was feeling in there, but I

*wanted to keep feeling it. That
yellow car became one of the
best parts of my week.*

In the far back corner of the sanctuary, unnoticed by anyone, the SHADOW FIGURE stands just outside an open doorway – unable, or unwilling, to come further in. It watches Chris, then withdraws into the light of the parking lot outside, gone.

EXT. BACKYARD - DUSK (FLASHBACK)

TEEN CHRIS (14) sits with his BEST FRIEND on an old porch step. The FRIEND'S OLDER BROTHER passes them a joint. Chris hesitates half a second, then takes it. Behind them, half-hidden by the treeline, the SHADOW FIGURE watches, closer now than it was at church.

*NARRATOR (V.O.): Weed came next.
Then someone handed me cocaine
like it was nothing. Four
strongholds now, and I hadn't
even finished growing up. The
seed my aunt planted that Sunday
didn't disappear. It just went
quiet for a long time.*

INT. FAMILY HOME - CHRIS'S ROOM - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)

TEEN CHRIS (16) lies on his bed, staring at the ceiling. His FATHER'S VOICE is heard faintly from another room – warm, present, but arriving late in the story.

*NARRATOR (V.O.): My father came
into my life late. I loved him.
Whatever I needed, he made sure
I had it. But by then I was
already carrying secrets nobody
in that house knew how to ask
about.*

INT. SCHOOL HALLWAY - DAY (FLASHBACK)

TEEN CHRIS (17) stands near a locker as a GIRL walks past without a glance, laughing with friends. His face falls. A second GIRL, weeks later – same result. He walks away alone, jaw tight.

NARRATOR (V.O.): I loved two girls, and both of them broke something in me I never fully put back. After that, I stopped trusting girls. And out of that wound – and the door already open from the abuse – I found myself in relationships I now know Scripture calls an abomination. I don't say that to shame myself. I say it because I stand on that truth now.

INT. CHRIS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT (FLASHBACK, YEARS LATER)

ADULT CHRIS, alone, phone screen lighting his face in the dark. Isolation on his features. He sets the phone down, exhausted in a way sleep doesn't fix.

NARRATOR (V.O.): Six strongholds now, living in the one house God built to be His own. My body. My temple.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. CHRIS'S APARTMENT - NIGHT (PRESENT-ISH)

A laptop glows on a small table. ADULT CHRIS sits before it, a YOUTUBE VIDEO paused mid-frame – a preacher mid-gesture, captioned something like 'How Satan Stops Your Prayers.' Chris stares at the screen a long moment before pressing play.

PREACHER (ON SCREEN, V.O.)

The enemy doesn't need to stop your life. He only needs to stop your prayers. Because if he can stop the prayer, he can stop everything that prayer was going to release.

Chris's eyes fill. Something breaks loose in his face – not despair. Recognition.

NARRATOR (V.O.): That video gave me a picture I'd never had. For the first time, I understood – this wasn't a willpower problem. This was a war. And it was fought in prayer.

INT. CHRIS'S APARTMENT - BEDROOM - NIGHT (MONTAGE)

A MONTAGE: Chris on his knees at his bedside, at first stiff and unfamiliar with it. Over several cuts – different nights, same room – his posture changes. Hands lifted. Head bowed low to the floor. Mouth moving in real, laboring prayer, not performance.

NARRATOR (V.O.): I started laboring in prayer – really laboring, the way scripture describes it. My house needed to become what it was always supposed to be. A house of prayer.

INT. CHRIS'S APARTMENT - BEDROOM - NIGHT (THE ENCOUNTER)

Chris kneels, deep in prayer, tears streaming, whispering and then speaking and then almost shouting – a release building. Light in the room shifts subtly, not with special effects spectacle, but with a quiet, warm intensity. In the corner, the SHADOW FIGURE recoils, smaller than it has ever

appeared, pressed back against the wall as the light grows. He gasps, as if something physically leaves him. The Shadow Figure is gone – not chased out in violence, simply unable to remain. He collapses forward, breathing hard, then laughs – a laugh of relief, not humor.

NARRATOR (V.O.): My first real encounter with the power of God. I was delivered. Not all at once in theory – in fact, that night, in that room. Something that had lived in me for years did not live there anymore.

INT. CHRIS'S APARTMENT - BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

Chris sits up slowly, wiping his face, looking around the room as if seeing it for the first time. He places a hand flat on his own chest.

CHRIS
This is Yours. It was always supposed to be Yours.

FADE TO:

EXT. OPEN FIELD / ANCIENT-LOOKING SET - DAY (SYMBOLIC SEQUENCE)

A stylized sequence, half-dream: A crowd of PEOPLE IN ANCIENT DRESS stack stone upon stone, building a tower that reaches into low clouds – frantic, competitive, some shoving others aside to add their stone first. Their language dissolves into overlapping, unintelligible shouting. The tower's top vanishes into confusion and fog.

*NARRATOR (V.O.): There's a way
to rise that God never asked
for. In Babel, they said, let us
build a tower, let us make a
name for ourselves. It ended in
confusion. In scattering.*

CUT TO: The same field, now empty of the tower. ADULT CHRIS walks alone through tall grass, unhurried, at peace, arms slightly lifted – not building anything, simply walking upward along a natural rise in the land, sunlight breaking through cloud above him.

*NARRATOR (V.O.): But there is
another way. Not built by human
hands. Built up, from the
inside, by the Spirit – praying
in the Holy Ghost, building
yourself up on your most holy
faith. Love. Joy. Peace. That's
the first level. Not a tower. A
life.*

INT. CHURCH SANCTUARY - DAY (PRESENT)

ADULT CHRIS stands at a podium or simply among a small gathered CONGREGATION, mid-testimony, visibly moved but steady. Faces in the crowd – some crying, some nodding, one young man in the back staring hard at the floor, recognizing something of himself.

CHRIS

God is coming back for a Church
without spot or wrinkle. Not
people who never fell. People
who fought – and reclaimed their
souls.

He looks directly toward camera, breaking the fourth wall gently, as if speaking past the room to the audience itself.

CHRIS (CONT'D)

If you know what I'm talking about – if you carry even one of what I carried – the same Spirit that delivered me is available to you. Build yourself up. Pray in the Holy Ghost. Ascend.

FADE OUT.

THE END